



The cavernous spaces of the Tanks house the complex, well-known installation, laid out in a nod to a typical memorial for some great departed figure. A pathway of red tiles leads from the metal entrance barriers all the way to the other end to a gateway made from metal trunks of diminishing size, the kind used by the poorest travelling workers in our country.

Near the middle of this pathway is a pyramid made from black marble and glass, within which is a white plaster corpse in the contorted position in which the man fell at the moment of death. Walking around, we realise the plaster cast and indeed the whole installation stem from an actual photograph—taken by photographer Hoshi Jal during the post Babri-destruction violence in Bombay in March 1993—of an anonymous, male riot victim lying dead in front of a low concrete structure on a road. This photograph of the dead man is repeated in a loosely circular conclave around the central pathway and the plaster body. Here he is curved into a concrete and metal shield; here he is as an almost imperceptible, darkly solarised ghost; here he is in a set of small prints, each hammered under with a grid of small nails, like a *baanshaiya*—except this bed of arrows can only be for us and our living perception.

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Memorial is a complex installation; with the artist working at many different material, historical and symbolic levels. On the black marble slab of the central pyramid-vitrine is an inlaid image that is a homage to Kazimir Malevich, the great Ukrainian-Soviet abstractionist painter; the pyramidal glass tomb itself reminds one of the tombs of Lenin and Stalin at the Kremlin, except here exhibited for history is not a 'great leader' but an anonymous, ultimately powerless victim of an ordinary man. Another floor-based vitrine displays a maze of blocks that remind one of architectural models of proposed projects, except this particular jumble could perhaps only be a Bombay *jhopadpatti*.

Engaging with this grim constellation in 2023, you find yourself asking whether it is just the ordinary man you are mourning or an idea of a nation and a society. You find yourself thinking about power and the many and repeated misuses of it, you think yourself thinking of shrouds, funeral pyres, processions, wakes for justice, for ideas of secularism and genuine democracy. Seeing *Memorial* installed in the Tanks of the Tate Modern, one of the world's major museums of contemporary art, just a few days after the loss of Sundaram himself (he was closely involved in the display), also changes the way you look at the work. You recognise that this is now immovably the fulcrum piece of the great and varied career of one of India's most powerful and important artists. Seeing the piece laid out in this international context, you also realise how it speaks quietly and clearly to not just Bombay and Babri, not just Naroda Patiya or Muzaffarnagar, but to many places across the globe. ■

Ruchir Joshi



RAJWANT RAWAT

1981: Sundaram participates in the pivotal *Place for People* group exhibition with Jogen Chowdhury, Sudhir Patwardhan, Nalini Malani, Bhupen Khakhar and Gulammohammed Sheikh—making figurative works that examine the artists' own worlds. The exhibition overturns the hegemony of the earlier generations of painters such as Husain, Souza and the Progressives group

1980s: Sundaram organises artist retreats and workshops at the Sher-Gil bungalow in Kasauli. Connected to the discussions at Kasauli, the influential *Journal of Arts and Ideas* begins to be published at this time, edited by Geeta Kapur and others

1993 onwards: Sundaram moves away from traditional painting on canvas and paper, concentrating on working in other media, including installations and digitally processed photography

1993: *Memorial*. Sundaram's first installation work is created as a response to the violence that follows the destruction of the Babri Masjid, especially the rioting and killings that target poor Muslims in Bombay

1991: In response to the first Gulf War, Sundaram produces a series of powerful drawings titled *Engine Oil and Charcoal* made from vehicle oil and engine detritus

1998: Sundaram executes a massive site-specific installation/performance at the Victoria Memorial in Calcutta, highlighting labour struggles in the context of imperialism and its aftermath. The project has now been distilled as a book, *History Project*

2000-2023: Several major exhibitions in India and internationally, including a retrospective at the Kiran Nadar Museum, *Step Inside and You are No Longer a Stranger/ Disjunctures*, and a show at Haus Der Kunst, Munich, both in 2018